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THA 211: Dramatic Literature and Criticism - From Aristotle to Soyinka

Read plays critically and argue about them without summarising the plot

THEATRE & FILM

Theatre & Film Studies

Faculty of Arts
Theatre & Film Studies | 200L

OUTLINE ARCHIVE: 2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Why this pack exists

Criticism is an argument about how a play works, supported by evidence from the text. This pack covers classical and modern critical standpoints, the vocabulary of dramatic analysis, and a repeatable method for writing a critical answer that goes beyond plot summary.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Apply Aristotle's poetics and later critical standpoints to a play.
- Analyse dramatic structure, character, language and staging implications.
- Distinguish description, interpretation and evaluation in criticism.
- Build a critical argument supported by textual evidence.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Critical standpoints

Each standpoint asks a different question of the same play.

- Classical: plot, character, thought, diction, song and spectacle; unity of action.
- Neoclassical: rules, decorum and the unities, later challenged by Romantic practice.
- Romantic and modern: expression, symbol and the director's interpretation.
- Marxist: class relations, ideology and the economic conditions of production.
- Feminist and postcolonial: gender, power and the politics of representation.
- Semiotics: signs, codes and how performance produces meaning.

> **Name the standpoint**
> If you use a postcolonial reading, say so. Naming the lens turns a set of opinions into a method.

Analysing a play

Use a checklist so you do not drift into retelling.

- Structure: act and scene divisions, turning points, use of time.
- Character: function, relationships, what each character wants and fears.
- Language: register, imagery, rhythm, silence.
- Stagecraft implied by the text: setting, props, entrances, offstage action.
- Context: the conditions of first production and the play's reception.
- Theme: what the play argues, not merely what it is about.

Writing the critical answer

Marks follow argument structure.

1. Open with a claim that answers the question directly.
2. Define the critical term you are using.
3. Give a quotation or specific moment as evidence.
4. Explain how the evidence supports the claim.
5. Acknowledge a counter-reading and answer it.
6. Close by returning to the question, not to the plot.

Criticism is an argument, not a verdict

A weak drama essay tells the examiner what happens and then announces that the play is good. A strong essay makes a claim that someone could disagree with and then proves it from the text. "Death of a Salesman is a tragedy because Willy Loman dies" is a plot summary; "Death of a Salesman works as tragedy because Miller makes Willy responsible for his own collapse while denying him the recognition that would make that responsibility meaningful" is an argument.

The difference matters because criticism exists to explain how a text produces its effects. Your evidence is always the same three things: what is said (dialogue), what is done (action and stage business), and how it is arranged (structure, staging, the sequence of information). Anything not traceable to one of those is your opinion, which is allowed, but must be labelled as such.

Aristotle is useful for structure and dangerous when treated as a checklist. The requirement that a tragic action be serious, complete and of a certain magnitude is a tool for testing whether a play holds together, not a licence to list six elements and award marks to Sophocles. Use one concept from a theorist to do one job in your argument, and say what that job is.

Reading a scene closely

Close reading in drama has to include the body and the space. A line delivered across a table is not the same line delivered across a battlefield, and a pause written into a script is an instruction about pressure, not a gap. When you quote, quote briefly and then analyse the mechanics: who speaks, to whom, what they want, what they avoid naming, and what the other character does in response.

Track the information gap. Most dramatic scenes run on a difference between what the audience knows, what one character knows and what another believes. Identify when that gap opens, when it narrows and who benefits from it staying open. This single habit will produce a better essay than any amount of adjectives about "tension".

Notice repetition. Playwrights repeat phrases because repetition is how theatre builds meaning over time; a line repeated in act three carries the weight of act one whether or not the character acknowledges it. Mark repeated words in your copy and ask what changed between the two occurrences.

> **The two-sentence test**
> State your thesis in one sentence, then state in the next what a reasonable opponent would say against it. If you cannot produce the opponent, your thesis is a description.

Using theory without drowning in it

Theory earns its place when it answers a question the text raises. A Marxist reading is appropriate when the play is organised around labour, ownership or class mobility; a feminist reading is appropriate when the play distributes speech, space and agency by gender. Applying a framework to a play it does not fit produces the familiar student essay in which the play disappears behind the vocabulary.

The practical method: choose one concept (for example, the gap between a character's social role and their interior life), define it in your own words, and then show three moments in the text where it becomes visible. If the three moments do not appear, abandon the concept rather than the evidence.

Cite theorists accurately and sparingly. A misattributed quotation is worse than no quotation, and an examiner who knows the source will notice. Where you are unsure of a wording, paraphrase and cite the idea, not the sentence.

OUTLINE ARCHIVE

Session record: THA 211

2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Year demarcation matters: a course code that existed in 2018 may have been renumbered, merged or dropped by 2019, and the department now also runs a film track. Read the year label before you rely on a code. The current entry below is a compiled map - take it to your course rep or the departmental office and confirm it before registration.

2018 — Archived course description — ARCHIVED

- THA 211 Dramatic Literature and Criticism
- Theories used by critics from Sophocles through Bernard Shaw to Wole Soyinka
- Development of literary criticism from classical and medieval theory to present controversies

Source: unizik.edu.ng - Theatre & Film Studies course description (page dated 31 May 2018; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2019 — Archived programme listing — ARCHIVED

- THA 211 Dramatic Literature and Criticism, 3 credits, first semester, 200 level
- Paired with THA 213 Critical Perspectives in Theatre History and THA 215 Basic Film Analysis
- THA 413 Theories of Dramatic Criticism and THA 412 Critics and Theoreticians in Africa continue at 400 level

What changed: The 2019 listing adds a 400-level criticism sequence that the 2018 description only implied.

Source: arts.unizik.edu.ng - Theatre Arts programme and course map (page dated 18 Oct 2019; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2025/2026 — Compiled working map — CURRENT WORKING MAP

- Dramatic literature and criticism remains the 200-level theory core
- Expect assessment through passage analysis and an argued essay
- Confirm your reading list early; play editions differ in translation and notes

Source: Compiled by ZikShare from the archived 2018 and 2019 departmental pages plus the published stress areas; this is a working map, not an official handout (retrieved 2026-10-22)

Archive means: this records what a public departmental page listed in that year. It is not a guarantee of the current curriculum, and ZikShare is not affiliated with UNIZIK.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. From plot summary to thesis

A draft sentence reads: "In The Lion and the Jewel, Lakunle is a modern man and Baroka is a traditional man, and the play shows the conflict between tradition and modernity." Rebuild it as an argument.

1. Name the problem: the sentence describes two characters and calls their difference a conflict without showing that anything is at stake.
2. Ask what the play actually does with the pair: which one wins, and what does the winning cost or reveal?
3. Draft a claim with a consequence: "Soyinka makes the modern suitor lose not because tradition is stronger but because Lakunle's modernity is rhetorical, and the play measures ideas by what they can actually deliver."
4. Add the counter-position: a reader could argue the play simply celebrates tradition.
5. State the evidence you will use: Lakunle's speeches versus Baroka's actions, and the final choice Sidi makes.
6. Check the claim is falsifiable: point to the scene that would disprove it.

> **What to carry forward**
> A thesis predicts evidence. If you cannot name the scene that would test it, it is not yet an argument.

2. Reading a silence

In a scene two characters argue, and one stops answering for eight lines. How do you write about that without inventing psychology?

1. Describe the stage fact: who is silent, for how long in the text, and what the other character does during it.
2. Note what the silence follows - usually a question the silent character cannot answer without losing something.
3. Compare with an earlier moment when the same character did speak; the contrast is the evidence.
4. State the effect on the audience's information: the silence withholds what the scene needs.
5. Offer an interpretation as an interpretation: "the silence functions as refusal", not "she feels ashamed".

> **What to carry forward**
> Write about what the script and staging do; attribute feelings only where the text supports them.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. Discuss the view that a good dramatic character is defined by what they want rather than by what they say.

20 marks

1. Define objective: a character's pursuit gives action its shape.
2. Support: show a play where stated intentions are contradicted by behaviour, and argue the behaviour is the truer evidence.
3. Complicate: in some dramatic styles speech is the action, and the linguistic register carries the want.
4. Bring in a second text to test the proposition across styles.
5. Conclude by qualifying: want explains structure, speech explains texture, and criticism needs both.

> **Where marks are lost**
> Choosing one side absolutely. The marks are in the qualification.

Q2. How does a playwright control the audience's knowledge, and why does it matter for criticism?

15 marks

1. Identify the mechanisms: revelation, concealment, overheard scenes, dramatic irony, delayed entrances.
2. Show one extended example of an information gap opening and closing.
3. Explain the effect: suspense, irony, judgement of characters.
4. Argue that criticism should trace management of knowledge rather than assert "tension".

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Thesis. The arguable claim an essay sets out to prove from evidence.

Dramatic irony. A gap between what the audience knows and what a character believes.

Objective. What a character is actively trying to achieve in a scene.

Obstacle. What prevents a character from achieving the objective, producing conflict.

Subtext. Meaning carried beneath the literal words, visible in action and context.

Catharsis. Aristotle's term for the purgation of pity and fear produced by tragic action.

Hamartia. The error or flaw in a tragic protagonist that contributes to their downfall.

Peripeteia. A reversal of fortune in the action of a play.

Anagnorisis. A moment of recognition or discovery that changes a character's understanding.

Close reading. Detailed analysis of specific textual and staging choices to support an interpretation.

Falsifiable claim. A claim precise enough that specific evidence could contradict it.

Canon. The body of works a discipline treats as central, always open to challenge.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - Argument

Thesis and evidence.

- Write three competing theses for one play.
- Test each against a scene that could disprove it.
- Choose one and outline five paragraphs.

Week 2 - Close reading

Mechanics.

- Annotate one scene for objectives and obstacles.
- Mark repeated words and their second occurrence.
- Write 600 words on a single page of text.

Week 3 - Theory

One concept, three moments.

- Pick a concept the text actually needs.
- Find three supporting moments.
- Define the concept in your own words.

Week 4 - Essay

Draft and cut.

- Write a full draft to the word limit.
- Cut every sentence that only summarises.
- Check quotations against the edition you cite.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- Aristotle, Poetics - read the sections on plot, character and recognition.
- Any standard introduction to dramatic theory covering realism, epic theatre and postcolonial criticism.
- The plays on your course outline, in editions with line numbers so you can cite precisely.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. What is the difference between description and evaluation?

Answer: Description states what is there; evaluation judges how well it works and for what purpose, with reasons.

2. Name three critical standpoints and the question each asks.

Answer: Marxist criticism asks how class and ideology operate; feminist criticism asks how gender and power are represented; semiotics asks how signs produce meaning.

3. Why is plot summary an inadequate answer?

Answer: It reports events without arguing how the play creates meaning, which is what the question assesses.

4. Give one staging implication embedded in a script you know.

Answer: A stage direction requiring sudden darkness implies dependence on lighting control, shaping mood and pace.

5. What does it mean to acknowledge a counter-reading?

Answer: To state a credible alternative interpretation and explain why your reading remains stronger.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Learn Aristotle's six elements and one limitation of the model.
- [ ] Read one play with a critical lens and take notes by scene.
- [ ] Write a 200-word passage analysis with three quotations.
- [ ] Define six critical terms in your own words.
- [ ] Draft an essay and label claim, evidence and evaluation in the margin.
- [ ] Remove every sentence that only summarises plot.
- [ ] Exchange drafts and check each other's use of evidence.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

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